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To cite this article: Asha Sunilkumar, Senthilkumaran Piramanayagam, Song Bee Lian, Bhakti More & Taramol K.G. (2026) Influencer marketing: a study of Gen Z's experiences and purchase decisions in the United Arab Emirates fashion industry, Cogent Business & Management, 13:1, 2672552, DOI: [10.1080/23311975.2026.2672552](https://doi.org/10.1080/23311975.2026.2672552)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/23311975.2026.2672552>



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Published online: 22 May 2026.



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Influencer marketing: a study of Gen Z's experiences and purchase decisions in the United Arab Emirates fashion industry

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ABSTRACT

The role of social media influencers is becoming pivotal in shaping Generation Z's consumer behavior in the fashion industry. This study explores how specific influencer attributes such as credibility, authenticity, empathy, engagement, and relevance shape young consumers' perception of fashion brands in the United Arab Emirates, specifically in terms of brand familiarity and brand credibility, and subsequently how these perceptions influence their purchase intention. Data were collected through a cross-sectional, self-reported survey of 271 Gen Z consumers and analysed using Covariance-Based Structural Equation Modelling (CB-SEM). The findings reveal that while authenticity and engagement exert a moderate effect on brand perceptions, influencer credibility and empathy significantly increase both brand familiarity and brand credibility. Influencer credibility, in particular, strongly influences purchase intention. The findings of this study offer a unique perspective on how Gen Z perceives and responds to influencer-centric marketing strategies in the study context.

ARTICLE HISTORY

Received 14 December 2025

Revised 3 May 2026

Accepted 7 May 2026

KEYWORDS

Influencer marketing;
Generation Z; UAE
fashion industry;
purchase intention; brand
credibility; brand
familiarity

SUBJECTS

Internet/Digital
Marketing/e-Marketing;
Retail Marketing;
Marketing Management

1. Introduction

Generation Z, born between 1995 and 2010, represents the first truly digital-native generation, distinguished by their deep integration with social media and sophisticated approach to digital consumption (Mahapatra et al., 2022; Sfodera et al., 2024). Unlike the previous generation, Gen Z expects authenticity and visually compelling content from brands they engage with, and this expectation has fundamentally reshaped how organizations approach marketing strategy (Coelhoso et al., 2022). In the fashion industry, where visual appeal and brand identity are paramount, digital media has increasingly replaced traditional marketing channels in shaping Gen Z's shopping and purchase intention (Bjerre, 2022). Consequently, fashion brands are compelled to adapt their marketing approaches to address the distinctive expectations of Gen Z consumers (Djafarova & Bowes, 2021; Özkan, 2017).

The United Arab Emirates presents a particularly compelling context for this investigation. With ~1.4 million digitally native Gen Z consumers who are highly engaged with social media (Ameen & Anand, 2020), the UAE represents a critical market segment for both domestic and international fashion brands. The region's fashion industry has undergone significant changes, driven by shifting consumer attitudes and the rapid growth of e-commerce (Khraim, 2018). What makes the UAE specifically significant for this study is that social media usage in the UAE exceeds the global average (Simon Kemp, 2025), facilitating

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a context in which influencer-driven communication is prominent. Despite this, Gen Z's purchase intention in the UAE fashion context remains empirically underexplored, leading to a knowledge gap.

At the heart of this study is influencer marketing—a leading mode of brand communication that has moved from novelty to necessity in the social media era. In the influencer marketing literature, influencer endorsements are often compared to celebrity endorsements, and research shows that influencers are more effective than traditional celebrities at driving brand acceptance (Schouten et al., 2020). According to recent studies, social media influencers serve as interactive branding agents that boost consumer engagement and brand value in digital spaces (Rajput & Gandhi, 2024). The growing significance of social media-driven brand communication in modern marketing ecosystems is reflected in the increased strategic usage of influencers (Ismagilova et al., 2020; Vrontis et al., 2021). The extensive use of social media platforms, especially in technologically advanced areas like the United Arab Emirates, with high levels of internet and social media usage rates, provides strong support for this expansion (Simon Kemp, 2025).

Previous research has examined influencer marketing and Gen Z's purchase behavior across various global contexts, including Turkey (Fatima & Erdoğan, 2023), Vietnam (Hoang-Long & Que-Nhu, 2024), and Indonesia (Ayuningtyas et al., 2024; Nugroho et al., 2022). These studies have highlighted the importance of Gen Z's experiences with influencer marketing for brand familiarity (Hoang-Long & Que-Nhu, 2024), brand credibility (Hoang-Long & Que-Nhu, 2024), and empathy (Li et al., 2023). However, significant research gaps remain. First, despite the UAE's strategic importance as a growing fashion market, no comprehensive studies have examined how influencer marketing affects Gen Z's purchase intention in this unique cultural and economic context.

Second, while prior studies have examined mediating mechanisms, particularly through brand perception constructs such as brand familiarity and credibility (e.g. Kareem & Venugopal, 2023), these effects are typically tested in isolation or within limited conceptual scopes. There remains a need to clarify how multiple psychological and brand-level mediators operate jointly within a broader theoretical structure linking influencer characteristics to purchase intention. Third, although multi-attribute models of influencer characteristics are well established, existing research often treats these attributes as independent predictors rather than integrating them within a unified, theory-driven framework. This study addresses this limitation by specifying how distinct influencer characteristics collectively influence purchase decisions through interconnected brand perception mechanisms, grounded in an integrated S-O-R, Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), and SIT perspective.

The research objectives are twofold: (1) to examine the effects of brand familiarity and brand credibility on Gen Z's purchase decisions in the fashion industry; and (2) to investigate how five key influencer characteristics, like empathy, authenticity, credibility, engagement, and relevance, influence brand familiarity and brand credibility, and thereby indirectly affecting Gen Z's purchase intention. By addressing these research gaps, this study makes several important contributions. From a practical perspective, it provides fashion marketers and brand managers in the UAE with evidence-based insights for designing effective influencer marketing campaigns targeted at Gen Z consumers. This study contributes to the influencer marketing literature by applying and empirically validating an integrated theoretical framework—drawing on the S-O-R model, social influence theory, and the Theory of Planned Behavior—in an underrepresented cultural context. While prior studies have employed similar integrations of theories, the current research extends this integration by providing context-specific evidence that highlights the relative importance of key influencer attributes for brand-related outcomes. Finally, this research provides empirical evidence from an understudied yet economically significant market, enabling academics and practitioners to refine their approaches to influencer-driven marketing strategies in the fashion industry.

2. Literature review and theoretical framework

This study integrates three complementary theoretical frameworks to explain how influencer attributes influence Gen Z's purchase intention in the UAE fashion industry. The Stimulus-Organism-Response (S-O-R) (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974) framework provides the overarching structural architecture for describing the interrelation among the study constructs illustrated in Figure 1, while social identity theory (SIT) explains the underlying psychological mechanism linking influencer attributes to brand perception. The TPB states that attitude toward the behavior, subjective norms and perceived control determine purchase decisions. In this context, brand perception and influencer-related factors are conceptualized as

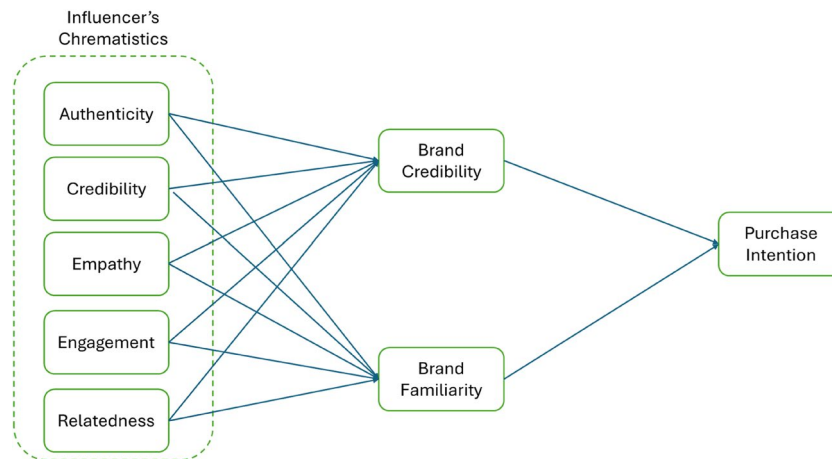


Figure 1. Conceptual framework of the study.

antecedents that shape consumer's attitude, which in turn indirectly influence purchase decisions. This section explicitly justifies the role and its integration.

2.1. Integration of different theoretical frameworks

The Stimulus-Organism-Response (S-O-R) Model (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974), widely applied in consumer behavior research (Jacoby, 2002), proposes that environmental stimuli influence internal cognitive and affective states, which, in turn, lead to behavioral responses. In the context of influencer marketing, we conceptualize, Stimulus (S): Five influencer characteristics—authenticity, credibility, empathy, engagement, and relevance—serve as marketing stimuli that Gen Z consumers encounter when they have exposed to influencer generated content; Organism (O): Brand perception specifically brand familiarity and brand credibility, represent the internal cognitive and affective evaluation that consumer form as a result of processing influencer related stimuli and Response (R): Purchase intention reflects the behavioral outcome, operationalized as a consumer's self-reported likelihood of purchasing fashion products endorsed by influencers. This model emphasizes that influencer characteristics do not directly trigger purchases but work through brand-level evaluations (Bi & Zhang, 2023; Eroglu et al., 2001; Hussain et al., 2023; Jacoby, 2002; YAQUB et al., 2023).

Social Influence Theory, originally proposed by Kelman (1958), explains the conditions under which social influences induce attitudinal or behavioral change (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004; Kelman, 1958). The theory posits that social norms within a group require individuals to demonstrate compliance and conformity. Further, three core motivational factors, such as accuracy, affiliation, and the maintenance of a positive self-concept, which are foundations for an individual's response to social norms or social influence, are emphasized by Cialdini and Goldstein (2004). In the current study, it helps to explain how influencer marketing affects Gen Z through compliance, identification, and internalization. In the UAE context, Gen Z may purchase fashion products by identifying with influencers whose values align with their own or by internalizing brand messages when perceiving influencers as authentic and credible (Davlembayeva et al., 2025; Joshi et al., 2025; Liang et al., 2024).

The third framework, the Theory of Planned Behavior (Ajzen, 1991), is widely used to predict behavioral intention in consumer research. TPB posits that behavioral intention, the immediate cause for actual behavior, is determined by three factors, including attitude toward the behavior, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control. In this study, we drew on TPB's foundational premises, which hold that attitude toward the behavior is a key determinant of behavioral intention. Subjective norms are conceptually distinct from influencer-driven brand perceptions. While an influencer may indirectly contribute to normative beliefs (eg, by signaling that "people like me" use this brand), the primary focus of this study is on how an influencer's traits shape followers' brand-level perceptions. As the primary focus of the study is to examine whether a favorable brand perception translates into purchase intention, rather than whether consumers feel capable of executing the purchase. Moreover, as perceived behavioral control (PBC) is more relevant in contexts involving high purchase involvement and significant resource constraints (Ajzen, 2002) its influence on the

purchase of fashion products is typically low. TPB is employed as a partial theoretical lens to explain the attitudinal pathway linking brand evaluations to purchase intention, rather than as a fully operationalized model. While TPB also emphasizes subjective norms and PBC, these components are not explicitly operationalized in the empirical model, and this study does not claim full TPB coverage. Perceived behavioral control is treated as contextually variable rather than uniformly negligible.

The integration of these three frameworks provides a coherent and theoretically grounded model. These frameworks complement each other. While S-O-R provides the basic structure, SIT explains how stimuli lead to the organism (brand familiarity and brand credibility) pathway. TPB supports in explaining the pathway between the organism and its link to the response. This integration approach positions this study as theoretically rigorous while remaining empirically feasible (Rahman, 2025).

2.2. Hypothesis development

Social media influencers shape brand perceptions by serving as opinion leaders and trusted intermediaries (Ha & Yang, 2023). Research demonstrates that influencer attributes such as authenticity, credibility, empathy, engagement, and relevance shape brand perceptions, though their relative importance remains to be empirically investigated. The study's hypothesis proposes relationships grounded in the integration of the S-O-R, SIT, and TPB frameworks. In the following section, we describe how five influencer attributes—authenticity, credibility, empathy, engagement, and relevance influence both brand credibility and familiarity, which in turn influence an individual's purchase intention. We acknowledge that these five traits of an influencer are interrelated, may be expected to show a higher level of correlation. Prior research has demonstrated that these constructs are highly correlated, but they have been used to exhibit different effects on consumer outcomes (Lou & Yuan, 2019; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020).

2.1.1. Influencer credibility and brand perceptions

Source credibility theory posits that competence, trustworthiness, and attractiveness of an information source significantly influence consumer perceptions (Hovland & Weiss, 1951; Maryati M & Utami, 2023). In the influencer context, credibility refers to the perceived reliability and expertise of the influencer as an information source, reflecting whether audiences believe the influencer's claims and recommendations are dependable. Influencers serve as opinion leaders on social media, and their legitimacy shapes how followers perceive recommended products. Influencers who are seen as informed and trustworthy may lend credibility to the brand they endorse, enhancing assessments at the brand level. According to this transfer effect, influencer credibility shapes internal cognitive responses like brand familiarity and credibility by acting as a stimulus within the S-O-R framework (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974). Influencer credibility differs from brand credibility, but through credibility transfer, credible influencers enhance the perceived credibility of the brands they endorse. This transfer mechanism can be understood through established theoretical perspectives, such as meaning transfer theory (McCracken, 1989) and halo effect principles (Thorndike, 1920), which suggest that favorable evaluation of the source can spill over to related entities (Yang, 2024). In the SMI context, this implies that influencer credibility may be transferred to the brands they endorse. Meta-analytic evidence indicates that source credibility dimensions significantly affect attitudes and intentions (Ismagilova et al., 2020). The source credibility, combined with consumer identification, positively impacts purchase decisions is demonstrated in Özbölük and Akdoğan (2022). Strong links between influencer credibility and brand credibility perceptions are found in Sesar et al. (2022). Regarding familiarity, influencer credibility enhances brand awareness and recall. Credible influencers enhance brand familiarity among Gen Z, thereby influencing purchase decisions and fostering loyalty, as demonstrated in Pinto and Paramita (2021). Credible sources enhance brand recall, making familiarity a natural consequence of trust-based communication (Ismagilova et al., 2020). While credibility is often empirically correlated with related constructs such as authenticity, it remains theoretically grounded in epistemic judgments of truthfulness and expertise, rather than expressive or identity-based evaluations. This distinction is important given prior findings of intercorrelation among influencer attributes (e.g. Lou & Yuan, 2019; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). In this study, we treat credibility as a cognitively oriented evaluation of message reliability, and its discriminant validity from authenticity is subsequently

assessed using standard SEM criteria (e.g. HTMT and Fornell–Larcker). Based on the above literature, we propose the following hypotheses:

- H1.** Influencer credibility has a significant and positive impact on brand familiarity.
- H2.** Influencer credibility has a significant and positive impact on brand credibility.

2.1.2. Influencer authenticity and brand perceptions

Influencer authenticity represents a distinct, though related, construct that captures the perceived genuineness and sincerity of the influencer's self-presentation, rather than the accuracy or reliability of their claims. Influencer Authenticity (Authenticity) is crucial for influencer efficacy. Conceptualization in two dimensions: moral authenticity (honesty, staying true to oneself) and practical authenticity (competence, expertise, genuine product usage) can be found in Audrezet et al. (2020). Authentic influencers augment trust and enhance brand reputations. Authentic influencers enhance purchase intentions by fostering trustworthiness, as demonstrated in Andonopoulos et al. (2023). Consumers regard brands promoted by genuine influencers as more reliable is found in De Veirman et al. (2017). However, authenticity is tenuous when consumers are skeptical about promotional content (Audrezet et al., 2020). According to Mehrabian and Russell (1974) Stimulus- Organism- Response framework, influencer authenticity serves as an external stimulus that molds internal cognitive assessments like brand familiarity and credibility. The commercialization of influencer marketing creates tension between partnerships and authentic connections. When successful, authentic influencers generate trust and consistent visibility, enhancing brand recognition. Authentic self-presentation strengthens consumer attachment and facilitates brand familiarity through repeated credible exposure (Audrezet et al., 2020). Credibility concerns whether the audience perceives the influencer's information as reliable and trustworthy, whereas authenticity relates to whether the influencer is seen as genuine and consistent with their true self.

Hence, we propose that:

- H3.** Influencer Authenticity has a significant and positive impact on brand familiarity.
- H4.** Influencer Authenticity has a significant positive impact on brand credibility.

2.1.3. Influencer empathy and brand perceptions

Influencer Empathy (Empathy) is the capacity to understand and feel others' emotional states (Riess, 2017). In marketing, empathy humanizes brands through influencers' emotional connections. Empathy-based marketing enables understanding consumers' feelings, leading to enhanced performance (Li et al., 2023). Empathetic influencers demonstrate an understanding of their followers' needs, creating emotional bonds that foster genuine perceptions and reinforce the credibility of endorsed brands. Brands showcased by empathetic influencers are perceived as more attuned to consumer preferences. Empathy positively influences customer forgiveness and repurchase behavior is shown in Wei et al. (2022). Empathetic advertising approaches shown to positively influence purchase behavior (Cai & Yu, 2022). Social Influence Theory (Kelman, 1958) states that identification with a source improves internalization of views, suggesting that follower's cognitive assessments of related brands are strengthened by influencer empathy. In influencer marketing, empathy builds emotional connections, strengthening brand credibility and enhancing brand familiarity by embedding brands within consumers' emotional landscapes, making endorsed brands more personally relevant and memorable.

- H5.** Influencer Empathy has a significant positive impact on brand familiarity.
- H6.** Influencer Empathy significant positive effect on brand credibility.

2.1.4. Influencer engagement and brand perceptions

Influencer Engagement (Engagement) refers to interactive influencer-audience relationships characterized by likes, comments, and shares. High engagement signals active communication, strengthening connections between influencers, audiences, and brands, and increasing purchase intentions among Gen Z.

High engagement has a positive influence on credibility perceptions, as demonstrated in Ismagilova et al. (2020). Engaged influencers facilitate identification and trust, thereby enhancing brand credibility (Schouten et al., 2020). Active engagement with fashion brands significantly strengthens consumer's purchase intentions (Thanasi-Boçe et al., 2022). While influencer credibility and content quality positively impact engagement, thereby a key determinant influencing the consumer purchase intentions (Chetioui et al., 2020). Influencer interaction increases message memorability, enhancing brand recall, as demonstrated in Lou and Yuan (2019). Increased engagement fosters brand familiarity through repeated exposure. Higher levels of influencer engagement reinforce followers' cognitive evaluations of related brands, consistent with the Social Influence Theory (Kelman, 1958), which asserts that interactive engagement promotes identification and internalization processes. Interactive social media activities significantly enhance purchase decisions in the luxury fashion sector is explained in Kim and Ko (2012). The above literature suggests the following hypothesis:

H7. Influencer Engagement has a significant positive impact on brand familiarity.

H8. Influencer Engagement has a significant positive impact on brand credibility.

2.1.5. Influencer relatedness and brand perceptions

Influencer relatedness refers to alignment between influencer content, audience interests, and product categories. The relevance between influencers and brand categories enhances engagement and brand familiarity, affecting purchase intentions, as discussed in De Veirman et al. (2017). Relevant messages boost consumer trust and brand attitudes (Lou & Yuan, 2019). By ensuring that influencer persona and brand positioning are consistent, influencer- brand fit increases source credibility and persuasive effectiveness (Breves et al., 2019). Content relevance is critical because consumers are more receptive to messages matching their interests. Meta-analytic evidence indicates that content alignment with consumer interests significantly supports credibility perceptions and influences purchase decisions (Ismagilova et al., 2020). This is particularly significant for the fashion industry, where relevance promotes brand credibility and fosters familiarity. Product-endorser fit has a significant influence on attitudes and purchase intentions for lifestyle products (Schouten et al., 2020). Recent research, however, shows that algorithm- driven visibility, audience segmentation, and strategic alignment within dynamic social media ecosystems are all examples of relevance in influencer marketing that go beyond static congruence (Hudders et al., 2021). Furthermore, relevance enhances both brand identification and trust-based assessments in the context of Gen Z, who are extremely sensitive to authenticity performance mismatches (Casaló et al., 2020). According to these recent findings, relevance serves as a strategic alignment mechanism in influencer- brand partnerships, strengthening favorable brand views in quickly changing digital landscapes. More recent studies also show that, especially among Gen Z customers in fashion contexts, brand views and purchase decision are strengthened when influencer communication and follower expectations are in line (Djafarova & Bowes, 2021; Sesar et al., 2022). The perceived relevance of influencer content to consumer interests serves as a stimulus that improves internal cognitive evaluations, such as brand familiarity and brand credibility, according to the S-O-R paradigm (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974). Additionally, influencer-brand relationships have changed as a result of continuous advancements in digital marketing technology and AI driven personalization (Dwivedi et al., 2023). Relevant content increases familiarity by capturing attention more effectively and facilitating deeper cognitive processing. Hence, we propose the following hypotheses:

H9. Influencer relatedness significantly and positively affects brand familiarity.

H10. Influencer relatedness significantly and positively affects brand credibility.

2.2. Brand perceptions and purchase decisions

2.2.1. Brand familiarity and purchase decision

According to Campbell and Keller (2003), brand familiarity is the quantity of brand-related experiences that consumers have accrued by previous exposure to and contact with the brand. By fortifying consumer's brand related knowledge structures, familiarity improves cognitive accessibility and accelerates information

processing (Alba & Hutchinson, 1987). Consumers use their stored brand knowledge more confidently during evaluation as familiarity grows, which has a beneficial impact on outcomes connected to purchases (Campbell & Keller, 2003). Brand familiarity is defined as accumulated knowledge and awareness about a brand (Acharya, 2021). For digitally savvy Gen Z consumers exposed to numerous brands across platforms, familiarity serves as a decision-making heuristic. Familiarity reduces perceived risk, streamlines evaluation, and generates higher quality perceptions, making Gen Z more inclined toward familiar brands. Social media platforms, particularly Instagram and TikTok, build brand familiarity through influencer content. Influencers have a positive impact on brand loyalty among Gen Z, with purchase intention mediating this relationship (Pinto & Paramita, 2021). Sustained influencer engagement increases familiarity, which in turn fosters both purchase intentions and loyalty. Brand related connections and awareness are strengthened in digital environments through frequent exposure to brand material via influencer marketing and social media. According to empirical studies conducted in influencer driven settings, Gen Z consumer's purchase decisions are positively impacted by social media exposure to branded content (Djafarova & Bowes, 2021; Sesar et al., 2022). Consistent brand messaging across interactive platforms improves brand related associations and aids in customer decision-making in modern digital contexts. The significance of cognitive brand familiarity in directing online purchase behavior is further highlighted by the growing complexity of digital ecosystems (Dwivedi et al., 2023). All of these results point to the role that brand familiarity plays in influencer-mediated fashion markets as a cognitive assurance mechanism that favorably influences consumer choices. According to the Theory of Planned Behavior, favorable purchase decisions are increased by familiar brands because they demand less cognitive effort and generate evaluative confidence (Ajzen, 1991). Based on the above literature, we propose the following hypothesis.

H11. Brand familiarity has a significant positive effect on Gen Z's purchase decisions for fashion products.

2.2.2. Brand credibility and purchase decision

Brand credibility refers to beliefs in a brand's trustworthiness and expertise (Erdem & Swait, 2004). Socially conscious Gen Z consumers carefully evaluate brands, placing a premium value on authenticity, ethical practices, and value alignment. Credibility is particularly crucial in fashion due to products' hedonic and symbolic significance. Gen Z is more inclined to purchase from brands regarded as legitimate and trustworthy (Lakmali et al., 2020; Nugroho et al., 2022). Brands prioritizing sustainability, inclusiveness, and social responsibility are perceived as more credible. Digital reviews and social media play vital roles, as Gen Z actively seeks influencer and peer recommendations (Khadar, 2020; Ozdemir et al., 2023). Influencer credibility positively relates to brand credibility (Sesar et al., 2022). While brand credibility and familiarity are conceptually related constructs- both indicate Individuals' cognitive evaluation of brands, they represent distinct dimensions of brand knowledge. Brand familiarity represents brand recognition, recall, and awareness, whereas brand credibility represents trustworthiness and perceived reliability. A consumer may be highly familiar with a brand, without necessarily perceiving it as credible, and vice versa. In this study, we expect that different influence traits will have varying effects on these two constructs. Brand credibility is pivotal in emerging economies, augmenting purchase decisions by ensuring consistency between brand assertions and consumer expectations is emphasized in Srivastava et al. (2020). As consumers develop more favorable opinions of a brand when they believe it to be credible, which increases their intention to make a purchase (Ajzen, 1991). Hence, we hypothesize that

H12. Brand credibility has a significant positive effect on Gen Z's purchase decisions for fashion products.

Based on the above literature and hypotheses, the following conceptual framework (Figure 1) has been proposed in this study.

3. Methods and materials

This study adopted a quantitative approach to examine the proposed hypothetical relationship between influencer attributes (authenticity, credibility, empathy, engagement, and relevance), brand level perception (brand familiarity and brand credibility), and Gen Z's self-reported purchase intention. The research design is cross-sectional and relies on self-reported survey data, which allows the examination of

theoretically grounded relationships among constructs. The directional relationship hypotheses in the study are grounded based on established theoretical frameworks, providing a rationale for the proposed pathway from influencer-related attributes to purchase intention through brand perceptions.

3.1. Ethics and informed consent statement

The study has considered ethics and informed consent for participants. Participants in the quantitative survey were informed of their consent to participate in the research and of anonymity via a Google Form they individually completed. The informed consent from the participants for participation in the research was written. The consent was taken through a Google form, which was circulated with details on the purpose of the research, the voluntary nature of participation and the right to withdraw at any point. The participation was anonymous and all data collected was used solely for academic purposes with confidentiality. All ethical approval for research is from the Office of the Ethics Committee of Manipal Academy of Higher Education Dubai via letter No. MAHE/REC_03/2025, dated 17 April 2025.

The data collection process commenced on 25 April 2025 and ended on 30 May 2025, with data analysis continuing until 30 August 2025, followed by revisions and discussion amongst the authors before submission of the manuscript. The data collected using the survey questionnaire were analyzed using different statistical procedures. First, descriptive statistics, including standardized factor loadings of each item under different constructs, Cronbach's alpha coefficients, skewness, and kurtosis values for each construct, were assessed to evaluate internal consistency and data normality.

The data were analyzed using covariance-based structural equation modeling (CB-SEM) implemented through IBM AMOS software (Version 26.0). Second, to assess the psychometric properties of the measurement model, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was adopted to evaluate the factor structure. Following the CFA, composite reliability (CR) and average variance extracted (AVE) were calculated to assess convergent validity, while the Fornell-Larcker criterion was adopted to test discriminant validity. Finally, the hypothesis is tested using structural equation modeling using AMOS SPSS software.

3.2. Population and sampling

The sample for this study consists of individual consumers aged between 18 and 28 in the UAE who have experienced the usage of influencer marketing in their purchase of fashion products.

The sample size for CB-SEM was determined based on established guidelines. While the traditional rule of thumb recommends 5 to 20 times the number of estimated parameters (Bentler & Chou, 1987; Tanaka, 1987), the recent literature emphasizes that sample size should be determined by the complexity, expected effect size, and statistical power (Wolf et al., 2013). As the measurement includes 25 items across eight constructs and the structural model tests 12 hypothesized paths, a minimum sample size of 250 is considered appropriate. The current 271 valid responses, which exceed the minimum threshold and align with the sample used in comparable CB-SEM studies in consumer behavior research (Ayuningtyas et al., 2024; Hoang-Long & Que-Nhu, 2024). The convenience sampling method was used to select the samples through an online Google Forms survey. Since the form was shared online, participants from different age groups took the survey, but we selected a convenient sample of young consumers aged 18-26 for the study. A total of 331 responses were collected, of which 271 were from Gen Z (Age range: 18-28).

3.3. Measures

Based on the literature review, the survey questionnaires were prepared. The first section of the survey collected respondents' demographic information, including age, gender, and profession. In the second part, the questions focus on the factors that influence Gen Z's behavior when purchasing fashion products. Specifically, brand familiarity (Che et al., 2025; Zeng & Lin, 2025) items were operationalized as perceived influencer-driven brand recognition by drawing on the conceptual framework of brand knowledge and prior exposure (Alba & Hutchinson, 1987; Campbell & Keller, 2003). Brand Credibility items were informed by the brand trust and expertise literature (Erdem & Swait, 2004; Sesar et al., 2022). Influencer

authenticity (Rao Hill & Qesja, 2023; Zniva et al., 2023) and credibility items were grounded in source credibility theory (Belanche et al., 2021; Hovland & Weiss, 1951) and subsequent influencer marketing research (Lou & Yuan, 2019). Influencer empathy items were developed based on conceptualizations of empathy in consumer-brand relationships (Riess, 2017). Influencer engagement items were informed by interactive engagement and consumer engagement literature (Schouten et al., 2020). Influencer-relatedness items were grounded in influencer brand fit and congruence literature (Belanche et al., 2021; Sesar et al., 2022). Purchase decision items were constructed consistent with established purchase intention research (Dodds et al., 1991; Gomes et al., 2022; Spears & Singh, 2004). The instrument underwent internal review to ensure clarity and contextual appropriateness prior to data collection. All items were measured using a five-point Likert scale with indicators 5-strongly agree, 4-agree, 3-neutral, 2-disagree, 1-strongly disagree. The items used in the measurement scale and their sources are presented in [Annexure A](#).

3.4. Demographic profile of the respondents

The demographic profile presented in [Table 1](#) reveals that the majority of the respondents were female (56.8%) and predominantly students (84.9%), indicating the young population.

While 54.61% ($n=148$) of the respondents belong to the age group of 22 to 25, 40.22% of the respondents belong to the age group of 25 to 28. Participants aged 18 to 21 constituted about 5.16%. Instagram emerged as the most frequently used social media platform (76.8%), followed by YouTube (9.56%) and TikTok (6%), suggesting a visual, trend-driven pattern of online engagement. Over half of the respondents (52.6%) frequently engage in online shopping for fashion items, though the majority (94.8%) reported making purchases between one and four times a month. In terms of following social media influencers for the purchase of fashion products, 43.7 per cent of respondents follow them monthly, and 25.7 per cent on a weekly basis.

4. Results

The data collected were analyzed using CB-SEM. This method is considered more suitable as the research is theory-driven and seeks to test theoretically predicted relationships rather than exploring emerging patterns. This approach is consistent with research examining theoretically grounded models in consumer behavior in the marketing context (Pereira et al., 2025).

The analysis consists of four stages. First, descriptive and diagnostic statistics, including standardized factor loadings, Cronbach's alpha, Skewness, and Kurtosis, were assessed to assess data normality and

Table 1. Demographic profile of the respondents.

Demographic variables	Details	No of respondent	Percentage
Gender	Male	117	43.2
	Female	154	56.8
Age	18–21	14	5.16
	22–25	148	54.61
	25–28	109	40.22
	Student	231	84.9
Occupation	Working professional	36	13.2
	Unemployed	7	1.8
	Instagram	209	76.8
Which social media platform do you frequently use?	Twitter	2	0.07
	Facebook	2	0.07
	TikTok	18	6.6
	You Tube	26	9.56
	Any other specify...	16	6
	Yes	143	52.6
Are you frequently using online shopping for fashion items?	No	129	47.4
	1–4 times a month	258	94.8
If yes, how often do you purchase fashion products online?	5–9 times a month	14	5.1
	5–9 times a month	4	1.5
	Daily	33	12.1
How often do you follow influencers on social media?	Weekly	70	25.7
	Monthly	119	43.7
	Any other specify	50	18.4

internal consistency. Multicollinearity among exogenous variables was assessed using the Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) analysis, with VIF values below 5.0 considered acceptable (Hair et al., 2019). A Cronbach's Alpha value greater than 0.70 is the benchmark for acceptable internal consistency (Saunders et al., 2009). Second, as the study data were collected via a self-reported survey, common-method bias (CMB) is a concern. To mitigate the risk, several procedural remedies were implemented during survey design. To statically check the CMB, Harman's single-factor test was conducted. Third, composite reliability (CR) and Average Variance Extracted (AVE) were also calculated to assess the convergent validity. Discriminant validity was evaluated using the Fornell-Larcker criterion, which mandates that the square root of each construct's AVE should exceed its correlation with other constructs (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). Fourth, a covariance-based structural equation model was estimated to test the hypothesized relationships among the constructs. Prior to the CB-SEM, a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was conducted to evaluate the measurement model's psychometric properties. The following section presents the outcomes of the four different processes adopted during the data analysis.

4.1. Descriptive statistics, reliability, and data normality

The result of descriptive statistics, including Standardized Factor loadings, Cronbach's alpha, Skewness, and Kurtosis, is presented in Table 2.

The results demonstrate the strong psychometric properties across all measures. The factor loading ranged from 0.512 to 0.891, indicating good item-construct relationships. Cronbach's alpha values (0.789–0.897) and composite reliability scores (0.812–0.923) exceed the threshold value of 0.70, confirming internal consistency. The skewness and kurtosis values fall within acceptable ranges (± 2 for skewness and ± 0.7 for kurtosis), suggesting an approximately normal distribution of the data. As the Cronbach's alpha values ranged from 0.7 to 0.89, scale item redundancy was not a concern. Furthermore, all factor loadings were below the threshold, suggesting that the indicators contribute uniquely to the latent constructs. Additionally, correlation values below 0.85 between constructs confirm the discriminant validity (Hair et al., 2019). An item of purchase intention (PURIN4) was removed due to poor factor loading; item BRFAM 1 (0.598) was retained in the analysis, as its removal did not improve model fit indices. This is confirmed by calculating AVE values before and after deletion; the construct revealed an acceptable convergent validity ($AVE \geq 0.50$). Multicollinearity among influencer attributes was assessed using VIF values. The VIF values for all exogenous variables ranged from 1.51 to 2.48, well below the commonly accepted threshold

Table 2. Factor loading, data normality and reliability.

Variables/Constructs	Items	Standardized factor loadings	Cronbach alpha	Skewness	Kurtosis
Influencer authenticity	INAUT1	0.840	0.879	0.203	1.365
	INAUT2	0.895		0.153	1.028
	INAUT3	0.809		0.092	0.619
Influencer credibility	INCRD1	0.883	0.894	0.125	0.842
	INCRD2	0.853		0.048	0.32
	INCRD3	0.843		0.245	1.649
Influencer empathy	INEMP1	0.876	0.896	0.261	1.756
	INEMP2	0.883		0.056	0.375
	INEMP3	0.868		0.084	0.563
Influencer engagement	INENG1	0.839	0.873	0.157	1.052
	INENG2	0.827		0.062	0.414
	INENG3	0.837		0.053	−0.358
Influencer relatedness	INREL1	0.899	0.838	0.097	0.649
	INREL2	0.846		0.067	−0.452
	INREL3	0.750		0.104	0.698
Brand familiarity	BRFAM2	0.799	0.855	−0.535	1.592
	BRFAM3	0.926		0.284	−1.908
Brand credibility	BRCRD1	0.796	0.886	0.148	0.993
	BRCRD2	0.906		0.044	0.299
	BRCRD3	0.846		0.079	0.528
Purchase intention	PURIN1	0.863	0.819	−0.199	−0.429
	PURIN2	0.809		−0.615	0.011
	PURIN3	0.662		−0.528	0.125
Model fit indices	Chi-square = 288.4, Df = 200, Chisq/df = 1.442, RMSEA = 0.040 (90% CI= [0.0310–0.0490]), RMR = 0.032, GFI = 916, CFI = 0.979				

of 5.0 (Hair et al., 2019), indicating that multicollinearity is not a significant concern in the dataset. Although VIF values indicate that multicollinearity is within the acceptable range, the conceptual overlap among influencer attributes that some degree of suppression or inflation cannot be entirely ruled out.

4.2. Common method bias

Harman's single-factor test was conducted to assess whether a substantial proportion of variance could be attributed to a single factor. While respondent anonymity was assured to reduce the social desirability bias, item orders were randomized where feasible to minimize the ordering effect. Negatively worded items were included to reduce the acquiescence bias. Harman's single-factor test was conducted to assess whether a substantial portion of the variance could be attributed to a single factor, following the recommendation by Podsakoff et al. (2012). The result indicates that no single factor accounted for more than 50 per cent of the variance. The first factor accounted for 34.13% of the total variance, suggesting that common-method bias is unlikely to be a major concern. However, we acknowledge that procedural and statistical remedies cannot fully eliminate common method bias, which remains a limitation of the study.

4.3. Composite reliability, convergent and discriminant validity

Composite reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity have been analyzed (Lowry & Gaskin, 2014). The results are shown in Table 3. The (Fornell & Larcker, 1981) criteria are used to establish discriminant validity. The average variance extracted values range from 0.521 to 0.748, indicating strong convergent validity, as they exceed the 0.50 threshold. As the square root of each factor's AVE is higher than its correlations with other variables, and the MSV values are lower than the AVE values. Hence, the variables under consideration have good discriminant validity.

4.4. Structural equation modeling and hypothesis testing

Structural equation modeling (SEM) is a multivariate statistical technique that combines the advantages of factor analysis and multiple regression to analyze the relationships between observed and latent variables. It consists of a measurement model, which assesses the indicators and their latent-variable relationships, and a structural model, which tests the causal relationships between the constructs. Measurement model used to validate whether the indicators accurately represent the intended construct using various model fit indices. Structural model maps the relationship, paths, or causal hypotheses. Model fit was assessed using multiple indices, and the results are presented at the bottom of Table 2. The model fit data with Chi-Square 288.4; Degrees of Freedom 200; $p=0.000$ and $CMIN/DF = 1.442 < 3$, imply the model is close to a good fit for the analyzed data, as RMR is 0.032 and GFI is 0.916. The Comparative Fit Index, CFI is $0.979 > 0.90$, and the Tucker-Lewis Index (TLI), which is an incremental fit index value of 0.965, indicates that it is a good fit for the model. To strengthen the robustness of the findings, alternative and nested structural models were tested. An alternative model that specifies the direct relationship between influencer attributes and purchase intention, without accounting for brand familiarity or brand credibility. The proposed model demonstrated the superior fit ($CMIN/DF = 1.442 < 3$; $RMR = 0.032$, $GFI = 0.916$, $CFI = 0.979$, $TLI = 0.965$) compared with the alternative model ($CMIN/DF = 3.78$; $RMR = 0.232$, $CFI = 0.784$, $TLI = 0.811$).

The results of the hypothesis testing presented in Table 4 reveal that influencer-related attributes drive brand perceptions and purchase intention among Gen Z consumers in the fashion industry. Among

Table 3. Composite reliability, convergent and discriminant validity.

	CR	AVE	MSV	MaxR(H)	INCRD	INAUT	INEMP	INENG	INREL	BRFAM	BRCRD	PURIN
INCRD	0.895	0.739	0.588	0.897	0.860							
INAUT	0.885	0.720	0.588	0.893	0.767	0.849						
INEMP	0.897	0.744	0.465	0.900	0.574	0.551	0.863					
INENG	0.873	0.696	0.465	0.873	0.576	0.569	0.682	0.834				
INREL	0.840	0.637	0.516	0.844	0.587	0.718	0.614	0.619	0.798			
BRFAM	0.855	0.748	0.187	0.886	0.172	0.355	0.132	0.107	0.243	0.865		
BRCRD	0.887	0.723	0.465	0.898	0.682	0.625	0.629	0.618	0.641	0.148	0.851	
PURIN	0.824	0.612	0.187	0.900	0.232	0.347	0.250	0.205	0.341	0.432	0.227	0.782

The bold value presented diagonally indicates the square roots of the variance shared by each construct.

Table 4. Regression weights.

Hypothesis	Relationship	Path coefficient	t-value	Result
H1	Influencer credibility → Brand familiarity	0.223	3.124	Supported
H5	Influencer empathy → Brand familiarity	0.192	2.131	Supported
H3	Influencer authenticity → Brand familiarity	0.088	0.705	Not supported
H7	Influencer engagement → Brand familiarity	0.320	4.044	Supported
H9	Influencer relatedness → Brand familiarity	0.357	3.124	Supported
H2	Influencer credibility → Brand credibility	0.517	6.461	Supported
H4	Influencer authenticity → Brand credibility	0.177	1.783	Not supported
H6	Influencer empathy → Brand credibility	0.151	2.111	Supported
H8	Influencer engagement → Brand credibility	0.048	0.775	Not supported
H10	Influencer relatedness → Brand credibility	0.125	1.390	Not supported
H11	Brand familiarity → Purchase intention	0.289	4.591	Supported
H12	Brand credibility → Purchase intention	0.463	7.466	Supported

different traits, influencer credibility shows a strong positive relationship with brand credibility ($\beta=0.517$, $t=6.461$, $p<0.001$), supporting H2. However, this interpretation should be made with caution, as the five influencer attributes are moderately correlated. In such cases, path standardized path coefficients may represent the unique contribution of each predictor while holding others constant. As a result, the result should not be interpreted as dominance of credibility, but rather as an indication of comparatively stronger influence within the specified model. Empathy also demonstrates a significant positive effect ($\beta=0.151$, $t=2.111$, $p<0.05$), supporting H6. However, three hypothesized paths were not supported: authenticity on brand credibility ($\beta=0.177$, $t=1.783$, $p>0.05$, rejecting H4), engagement on brand credibility ($\beta=0.048$, $t=0.775$, $p>0.05$, rejecting H8), and relatedness on brand credibility ($\beta=0.125$, $t=1.390$, $p>0.05$, rejecting H10). This is a noteworthy finding given the strong emphasis on authenticity in prior literature. This outcome suggests the potential overlap in explanatory variance with other influencer attributes such as credibility and empathy. In terms of brand familiarity, four influencer attributes have a significant impact. Influencer relatedness shows the strongest effect ($\beta=0.357$, $t=3.124$, $p<0.01$), supporting H9, followed by engagement ($\beta=0.320$, $t=4.044$, $p<0.001$, supporting H7), credibility ($\beta=0.223$, $t=3.124$, $p<0.01$, supporting H1), and empathy ($\beta=0.192$, $t=2.131$, $p<0.05$, supporting H5). However, authenticity does not significantly predict brand familiarity ($\beta=0.088$, $t=0.705$, $p>0.05$), leading to rejection of H3.

Both brand familiarity ($\beta=0.289$, $t=4.591$, $p<0.001$) and brand credibility ($\beta=0.463$, $t=7.466$, $p<0.001$) demonstrate significant positive effects on purchase decision intention, supporting H11 and H12. Notably, brand credibility exhibits a substantially stronger effect than brand familiarity, suggesting that trust-based brand evaluations matter more than mere brand recognition in driving purchase intentions among Gen Z consumers.

5. Discussion

This study aims to answer a question that has become a core element of fashion marketing in the digital era: how do the specific traits of social media influencers, such as credibility, authenticity, empathy, engagement, and relevance, drive the way Gen Z consumers in the UAE perceive fashion brands, which ultimately influence their purchase intention. The study integrates the Stimulus-Organism-Response (S-O-R) framework, Social Influence Theory (SIT), and the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) to address the research question.

Among different attributes, influencer credibility demonstrated significant positive effects on brand credibility and brand familiarity. The finding strongly aligns with the source credibility theory (Hovland & Weiss, 1951; Serman & Sims, 2022) and recent empirical works that demonstrate influencer credibility as a foundation for social media influencer marketing. Our findings echo (Sesar et al., 2022), who found the strong link between influencer credibility and brand credibility perceptions, and extend (Pinto & Paramita, 2021), who demonstrated that credible influencers enhance brand familiarity among Gen Z, thereby influencing purchase-related decisions. These findings are consistent with our SIT grounded theoretical framework. The theoretical explanation for credibility as a dominant attribute operates through what we might call the transfer of perceived credibility across domains. When Gen Z consumers perceive an influencer as knowledgeable and trustworthy about fashion, they transfer these evaluations to the brand that the influencer endorses (Ismagilova et al., 2020). This finding also aligns with the notion of transfer of

credibility, where a favorable evaluation of a source extends to related objects through a spillover mechanism (McCracken, 1989; Thorndike, 1920; Yang, 2024). The second most important attribute, with a significant positive effect on both brand familiarity and brand credibility, is influencer empathy. Compared to credibility, the effect is smaller in magnitude. Empathy nonetheless emerges as a meaningful contributor to brand perceptions. This finding aligns with recent theoretical and empirical work emphasizing the role of empathy in humanizing brands through influencer association. Empathy-based marketing enables the understanding of consumers' feelings demonstrated in Li et al. (2023), and empathy positively influences consumers' behavior is shown by Wei et al. (2022).

Influencer engagement demonstrated an interesting pattern. While it significantly predicted brand familiarity, it failed to significantly predict brand credibility. It reveals that when influencers actively engage with followers through comments and responses, they generate repeated exposure to brands they support. This exposure naturally increases brand recognition, recall, and awareness. From the S-O-R framework perspective, engagement-based stimuli strengthen familiarity through exposure (Alba & Hutchinson, 1987). However, the interaction alone cannot necessarily signal credibility (Hovland & Weiss, 1951). Our findings align with Kim and Ko (2012), who found that interactive social media activities significantly enhance purchase decisions. In terms of influencer relevance, it reflected a pattern similar to engagement. While it is highly predictive of brand familiarity, it failed to demonstrate a significant influence on brand credibility. The finding implies that when influencers' content on fashion products closely matches followers' personal preferences, the followers naturally pay more attention to the brands featured in that content. It also indicates that relevance alone does not guarantee that the influencer is perceived as trustworthy or an expert in the domain. Another intriguing finding of the study is the insignificant impact of influencer authenticity on brand familiarity and brand loyalty. This finding contradicts much of the established literature, which consistently identifies authenticity as a critical trait of influencers (Audrezet et al., 2020). In a highly saturated influencer marketing environment like the UAE, authenticity may have become a baseline expectation rather than a differentiator. This interpretation aligns with Siddharajsinh et al. (2025), who found that while authenticity matters for initial trust formation, its marginal effects diminish in the context where consumers have extensive prior experience with influencer content. Having examined how influencer attributes influence brand perception, we now turn to the second stage of the proposed conceptual model, which describes the theoretical relationship between consumer brand-related perceptions and their translation into purchase intention. The results indicate that both brand-related perceptions, including familiarity and credibility, significantly predicted purchase intention. However, between the two constructs, brand credibility exerts a substantially stronger influence on purchase intention than brand familiarity. This pattern aligns with theoretical predictions from signaling theory, which suggests that trust-based evaluation is more important for purchase decisions than recognition and awareness. The reasons credibility is considered an important factor influencing consumer decisions are multiple. While the cost of fashion purchases may be low, they still entail social and psychological risks. Brand credibility signals that a brand consistently delivers quality, which reduces perceived risk. As brand credibility encompasses these value judgements, familiarity is not necessarily aligned with these values. Moreover, when Gen Z is exposed to multiple fashion brands daily across multiple platforms, familiarity alone cannot differentiate among this vast array of known brands. Credibility could be a more meaningful criterion for narrowing choices and committing to purchase. Our findings closely align with recent empirical work across multiple contexts. Brand credibility mediated the relationship between influencer traits and purchase intention, as found in Kareem and Venugopal (2023). Brand credibility is a pivotal factor that influences consumer behavioral intention, as emphasized by Srivastava et al. (2020).

Our finding makes several contributions to influencer marketing theory. First, by positioning the S-O-R framework as a basic structure, social influence theory as a psychological mechanism, and TPB to describe the behavioral outcome, this study demonstrates that influencer marketing effects operate through a complex process rather than a simple persuasion. The integration of multiple theoretical frameworks offers greater parsimony than a single theoretical approach in explaining antecedents and outcomes. Second, the findings strongly support the proposition that influencer attributes influence purchase intention through brand perceptions rather than having a direct influence. This logic is consistent with S-O-R: influencer characteristics act as stimuli, further directing consumer evaluation of brands, which ultimately drives purchase intention. Third, the insignificant effect of authenticity represents an important

theoretical contribution by highlighting the contextual relevance of influencer attributes. Information source characteristics and their effect on the target or individual may vary across cultural contexts, environments, and product categories. This provides scope for further research to focus on context rather than assuming universal effects. Fifth, credibility matters substantially more than brand familiarity for purchase intention, extending the signaling theory that posits that trust-based evaluation dominates in high-involvement products.

In terms of practical implications, the results yield a few actionable insights. First, the marketers need to weigh influencers' perceived expertise and trustworthiness, which reflect their credibility when selecting them as brand ambassadors or brand partners. The main emphasis is that marketers need to go beyond follower counts, engagement rates, and aesthetic appeal. Partnering with well-established fashion writers, professional designers, and micro influencers who are known for their knowledge, reputation, and honesty, while creating their content. Second, marketers need to understand that a single influencer type cannot achieve all the objectives of social media marketing. Using engagement-focused and relevance-driven influencers for awareness campaigns, then shift to credibility focus and empathy-driven influencers for conversion campaigns. Third, instead of focusing on marketing objectives and key performance indicators in terms of impressions and awareness, marketers need to move on to building brand trust and credibility. It requires a long-term partnership with influencers who can tell brand stories connecting product quality, values and reliability. Fourth, train influencer partners to demonstrate a genuine understanding of follower's concerns, particularly around affordability, diversity in body shapes and sustainability in fashion. Influencers need to position the brand as part of the solution while focusing on building awareness and trust simultaneously. Fifth, as brand credibility drives purchase intention that brand familiarity, marketers need to invest proportionately more in building credibility-related activities consistent with product quality and value.

The present study is subject to a few limitations. The cross-sectional design enables the researcher to study the theoretically predicted relationship between variables, but not the definitive causal influence. Future research should employ different research designs to support the causal mechanism between constructs. Longitudinal studies that track changes in influencer exposure, brand perception, and purchase behavior across multiple time points, or experimental studies that manipulate influencer attributes through vignettes or mock influencer profiles, can be used to test causality. The use of convenience sampling through social media platforms induces substantial selection bias. A key limitation of this study is its student-dominant sample, which limits the generalizability of the findings to the broader Gen Z population. As students represent a distinct consumer segment with potentially different levels of disposable incomes, social media engagement, and brand evaluation patterns, future studies should validate these findings across more occupation-driven Gen Z samples. As data were collected using a self-report instrument, it increases the risk of common method variance. Future research can be conducted using a combination of consumer surveys and actual purchase data, or influencer engagement analytics. Although the study draws on the Theory of Planned Behavior, it does not adopt all core constructs. Future research could extend the model by incorporating both subjective norms and perceived control. Moreover, as the focus was exclusively on the UAE fashion industry, it limits the generalizability to other geographic contexts and product categories. Future research can test the model across diverse cultural and economic contexts. This study also extends the scope for future research to investigate potential moderators and mediators, as well as the intention-action behavior gap.

6. Conclusion

This study examined how influencer attributes influence Gen Z's purchase intention in the UAE fashion industry by combining three theoretical frameworks. Using cross-sectional survey data from 271 Gen Z consumers, analyzed using covariance-based structural equation modeling, this study provides evidence that influencer credibility and empathy have strong effects on both brand familiarity and brand credibility, which, in turn, positively influence consumers' purchase intention. A noteworthy contribution of the study is that influencer authenticity does not significantly affect either brand familiarity or brand credibility. This result contrasts with the dominant assumption in the influencer marketing literature, which often positions authenticity as a central driver of consumer response. This finding suggests that, in a highly saturated

influencer environment, authenticity may be a basic expectation rather than a differentiating attribute. The finding reinforces the idea that not all influencer attributes contribute equally to brand attributes and purchase decisions. The study concludes that brands can endorse successful marketing if influencers demonstrate strong credibility. Brands must devise social media strategies for fashion marketing to Gen Z (Palomo-Domínguez et al., 2023). Findings of this study significantly contribute to the ongoing discussions on influencer marketing and the significance of influencer traits that drive Gen Z purchase intention.

Acknowledgements

The authors acknowledge the respondents of the survey for their insights.

Author contributions

CRedit: **Asha Sunilkumar**: Data curation, Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Software, Validation, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **Senthilkumaran Piramanayagam**: Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Methodology, Software, Validation; **Song Bee Lian**: Formal analysis, Methodology, Project administration, Supervision, Validation, Writing – review & editing; **Bhakti More**: Data curation, Project administration, Writing – review & editing; **Taramol K.G.**: Conceptualization, Data curation, Resources, Writing – review & editing.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

There was no funding for this research.

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Data availability statement

Data supporting the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request.

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Annexure A measurement scale and items

Influencer Credibility (Adopted from Belanche et al. (2021), Hovland and Weiss (1951))

The influencer whom I follow is knowledgeable about fashion

The influencer whom I follow is a reliable source of information of fashion

The influencer whom I follow is trustworthy when recommending fashion brands

Influencer Empathy (Adopted from Riess (2017))

The influencer whom I follow understands the followers' fashion preferences

The influencer whom I follow cares about their audience

The influencer whom I follow shows genuine concern for the interests of their audience

Influencer Engagement (Adopted from Schouten et al. (2020))

The influencer whom I follow actively interacts with the followers

The influencer whom I follow responds to comments and messages

The influencer whom I follow creates content that encourage audience participation

Influencer relatedness (Adopted from Belanche et al. (2021), Sesar et al. (2022))

The influencer whom I follow creates content that is relevant to my interests

The influencer whom I follow recommendations are fit for my lifestyle

The influencer I follow posts are aligned with my personal style

Influencer authenticity (Adopted from Rao Hill and Qesja (2023), Zniva et al. (2023))

The influencer whom I follow is genuine.

The influencer whom I follow is authentic

The influencer whom I follow is real to me

Brand Familiarity (Adopted from Che et al. (2025), Zeng and Lin (2025))

I am very familiar with the fashion brand promoted by the influencer I follow

I can quickly recognize the fashion brands among other brands

I can easily recall the fashion brand associated with my favorite influencer

Brand Credibility (Adopted from Erdem and Swait (2004), Sesar et al. (2022))

The fashion brand delivers what it promises

This fashion brand is trustworthy

This fashion brand has a reputation for being reliable

Purchase intention (Adopted from Ajzen (1991), Dodds et al. (1991), Gomes et al. (2022))

I intend to purchase a fashion brand recommended by the influencer whom I follow

I am likely to buy a fashion brand after seeing the influencer's posts

I plan to consider influencer recommendations when making purchases of fashion products

I would encourage people close to me to buy the fashion brand promoted by the influencer